## Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

## Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

   We go to Costco, we go to Lucky, we go to Walmart. From there, we buy whatever we like. When the children come back from school, I prepare food for them, I cook whatever they like, such as pasta, rice, and meat. I am content and comfortable. It is not that I cannot buy things; we can buy everything.

2. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

   My husband was unemployed and had no job at all. We were very worried during that time. It was good that we had food stamps; at least we didn't have to worry about food. If those had run out, we would have to be very careful and wouldn't have to buy things like popcorn for the kids. We tried our best to make it through until he found a job, after four months, he finally got a job, and the problem was solved. Our main worry was how we would manage to find food if he didn't get a job. When he is working, there is money, and feels relaxed. That was our concern.

   a. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

Our Food Stamps have been cut off, we went to the refugee center and called to get it sorted out. It took almost a month, about 20 days, to get it fixed. This was very stressful. We didn't have any other worries. Two or three months ago when we moved some documents were lost, and we should have reported within six months. Because we didn't, our food stamps were cut off. Then we went back, filled out the forms, and finally it was resolved.

   b. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

When we go there, they help us. We give them our case number, and they handle our issues. If we need a translator, they arrange one for us. At another place, they didn't suggest getting food from anywhere else. We just went and said that our food stamps had been cut off. They told us to fill out the forms and bring it back.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

They did a very good job with everything. Whenever they don't understand something, they guide us both the IRC and Refugee Center are very helpful. I am very satisfied. When I go there, I don't face any problems. Whatever I mention, they find someone who speaks my language, or they call on the phone for a translator, and all the issues get resolved.

ii. Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT

It is very difficult when the rent is $3000 per month, and some of it is covered, but the rest is on us. Without food stamps, it is very challenging. We receive a little less because we are 10 people, and $1300 comes in, but there is still a $200 shortfall at the end of the month. Since there are so many of us, my children sometimes crave things like ice cream, and I must tell them to wait another week. Other than that, we manage to be content. Whenever hopefully, all of them start working, things might get better. But for now, it is tough.

i. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

We are very happy with the food assistance we receive. There is a free course where we can study, and we don't expect much more than this.

ii. You indicated that you have used the WIC program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

When we first arrived, the IRC helped us a lot. They told us to take my children and apply for the WIC program. I went there, gave them the names of my children, and they issued us a card. The IRC even scheduled the appointment for me. The WIC doctors also came to the IRC, and it felt good they asked about everything and checked up on us three months later, six months later, and so on. That is why I am very satisfied and found it very easy. I did not face any problems.

iii. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

We have been using this program since we arrived, and it has been there for years now> Our experience is that it is very good for us, and it is a great help for immigrants.

iv. Tell me about the food you received from them.

For a while, it was $1600, which was very good. Now they have reduced it by $200, we receive $1400. It makes it harder for us at the end of the month, but It's still okay. The expenses for the children are high.

v. What % of your foods come from this program?

We are receiving $1400 with the present which could be 70%.

vi. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

We didn't have much, just enough to avoid any problems. We never had any issue with food, but the thought of being without food stamps did cross our minds. It would be very difficult without them. Since we came to America, we haven't faced any food problems at all because we've always had food stamps from the time we arrived until now.

vii. Have you asked your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you because they help refugees find food resources?

No

viii. Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

c. You indicated that you never had problems with food in the last 12 months. Research shows that many refugees experience food insecurity. Can you explain what things have helped you to have enough food for yourself and your family?

d. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

They helped us a lot by assisting with our food stamps application, which was the most important support we received. However, they did not show us the farmers' market or another place where we could find free food.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?
ii. Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from
<RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Yes, we go to the refugee center (DWS), and they provide us with an interpreter. If we need any documents, we bring them, and they help us with everything. They solve all our problems, and if there is anything they need, they keep us informed.

iii. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

From my experience, I feel happy when our children are checking. They assist their weight and blood to determine how they are doing, what their weight is, and what they need. I am satisfied with this program and have found a lot of comfort in it, it is clear how much milk, eggs, and beans are provided, and they prepare enough food.

iv. Tell me about the food you received from them.

I receive eggs, beans, and milk from this program

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

In our culture, rice is essential, and we need to buy it along with flour and meat. We buy these things at Costco and from halal markets. Even when we first arrived, our caseworker took us in guided us on how to use the bus, how to come and go, and provided us with a lot of assistance.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

It is so important for us to eat our culture's food we can't eat haram things it is so important

b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

Every store has everything, and we get all our things from WinCo. It has everything we need, just like all the stores here.

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

They guided us according to our culture, telling us which stores have halal products, and which markets carry specific foods. They pointed out where to find halal items and mentioned which halal market we could shop at. However, they didn't take us in a car to show us these places; they simply informed us verbally.

i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

**Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)**

This is the last section of our interview, and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

   Food stamps are a great resource for new immigrants. They are one of the most important things until we can find a job, and even if the work is not enough money to buy food, food stamps are the best support we have. It's something we cannot do without. This country doesn't discriminate; everyone is treated equally regardless of whether you are Afghan or from another country. I have never seen anything like this before. The people are very kind, and we are very satisfied with how well we are treated equally.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

In this country, the government has systems in place for every refugee who arrives. There are organizations like the IRC and CCS that provide support. There is not a situation where someone arrives and is left without any resources or knowledge. It's not like that. When we came, we didn't encounter any problems; everything was prepared for us.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

They provide food stamps, which ensure that people have access to food. Here, everything is managed efficiently. If a person is working less, they receive more assistance, and if they earn more, they receive less. No one is left without food here. If food stamps are not enough, one can still manage well with a good job and buy what they need. We are very satisfied with this system; it works well for us.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   We are very satisfied with the support from the IRC and the refugee center. We have not faced any problems. Everything follows a proper procedure, which has been beneficial for us. They helped us for two years, and once we were self-sufficient and understood everything, we needed to navigate our new life, they said goodbye to us.